MISH 17
Use and Care of Ladders

DIGITAL ACCESS
mhc-gc.com/resources/safety-manual/section/17

DOCUMENT	MISH 17	**REVISION**	2	**EFFECTIVE**	04/07/2026
PROGRAM	MH Construction Industrial Safety & Health Program (MISH)				
LICENSES	WA: MHCONCI907R7 · OR: 765043-99 · ID: RCE-49250				

Ladder Use & Care

DOCUMENT	REVISION	EFFECTIVE DATE	APPROVED BY
	2	04/07/2026	Jeremy Thamert

MH CONSTRUCTION INDUSTRIAL SAFETY AND HEALTH PROGRAM

Title

USE AND CARE OF LADDERS

Number

Revision 1 Approved By Jeremy Thamert 03/01/2025 Name Date Effective Date 3/1/2025 Page 1 of 5

1.0 PURPOSE

To define responsibilities and requirements for the safe use, handling, storage, and construction of ladders. Further, to ensure compliance with applicable requirements of the American National Standards Institute (ANSI), Occupational Safety and Health Administration/Washington Industrial Safety and health Act (OSHA/WISHA), and the National Fire Protection Association (NFPA) requirements.

2.0 RESPONSIBILITY

2.1 The Key Supervisor shall be responsible for ensuring compliance with this procedure.

2.2 Employees shall be responsible for complying with the provisions of this procedure.

3.0 DEFINITIONS

Competent Person: One who is capable of identifying existing and predictable hazards in the surroundings or working conditions which are unsanitary, hazardous, or dangerous to employees, and who has authorization to take prompt, corrective measures to eliminate them. A Competent Person is also one who has extensive knowledge/experience in a particular activity or job function.

4.0 GENERAL REQUIREMENTS

4.1 Use, care, and storage of ladders shall comply with the following statutory requirements:

- 29 Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) 1926, Subpart X; Stairways and Ladders.
- 29 Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) 1910, Subpart D; Walking and Working Surfaces.
- Washington Administrative Code (WAC) 296-876 Ladders, Portable and Fixed. (WAC) 296-155-475 - 296-155-477 Stairways

4.2 Ladders shall be maintained in good condition at all times. Those that are defective in any way shall be removed from service and tagged with an unsafe equipment tag until made safe for use, or destroyed.

4.3 Ladders may be repaired only if repairs will restore the ladder to a condition meeting its original design criteria.

4.4 Ladders used on Construction Sites shall be appropriate for industrial applications (Class I or 1-A). Light-duty household ladders are not permitted.

4.5 Ladders shall not exceed the length limits established for each type as follows:

Type Maximum Length Limit

Single, portable ladders 30 ft Two-section extension ladders 60 ft Step ladders 20 ft Mason's ladders 40 ft

4.6 On two-section extension ladders, the minimum overlap for the two sections in use shall be as follows:

Ladder size Overlap

< 36 ft 3 ft 36 ft to 48 ft 4 ft 48 ft to 60 ft 5 ft

4.7 Job-made ladders shall be constructed in accordance with ANSI A14.4, "Safety Requirements for Job-Made Ladders".

4.8 Ladder safety devices may be used in lieu of cage protection on fixed ladders of unbroken length. Landing platforms shall not be required in these cases except at regular step-off points. All ladder safety devices shall be compatible with the ladders with which they are used and shall permit the user to ascend or descend the ladder without pushing, pulling, or continually holding any part of the device.

4.9 When ascending or descending a ladder, the user shall face the ladder.

4.10 Metal ladders shall not be used where potential electrical hazards exist. Wood or fiberglass ladders having metal parts (other than hardware) shall not be used where potential electrical hazards exist unless they bear a manufacturer's label that indicates the following:

- The ladder complies with ANSI A14.5
- The ladder is approved for electrical use

4.11 Wood ladders shall not be coated with any opaque covering (i.e., paint) except for identification or warning labels, which may be placed on one face only of a side rail.

4.12 Employees shall be trained to the requirements of this procedure.

5.0 PROCEDURE

5.1 USE OF LADDERS

5.1.1 The user before each use shall inspect ladders.

5.1.2 Employees shall ensure that their shoes and the ladder steps are free of grease, mud or other materials that could cause them to slip while climbing.

5.1.3 Ladders shall not be placed against operational piping such as acid lines, compressed gas lines, sprinkler piping, conduit, etc.

5.1.4 Straight ladders shall be used at an angle of approximately 75 degrees from the horizontal. (This position may be readily established by placing the base of the ladder ¼ of its working length from the vertical plane of the top support.)

5.1.5 No type of work shall be performed on a ladder 25 ft or more from the ground or floor unless a safety harness is worn and the safety lanyard is secured to an adequate fall arrest or fall restraint attachment point.

5.1.6 Objects that restrict use of both hands for climbing shall not be carried in the climber's hands.

5.1.7 Ladders shall be used only on firm, stable and level surfaces and shall be secured to prevent accidental displacement.

NOTE: Step ladders need not be secured except when required by subparagraphs 5.1.7.1 and 5.1.7.2.

5.1.7.1 Ladders shall not be used on slippery surfaces unless secured or provided with slip-resistant feet to prevent accidental displacement. Slip-resistant feet shall not be used as a substitute for care in placing, lashing, or holding a ladder that is used upon slippery surfaces including, but not limited to, flat metal or concrete surfaces that are constructed so they cannot be prevented from becoming slipper.

5.1.7.2 Ladders placed in any location where they can be displaced by workplace activities or traffic, such as in passageways, doorways, or driveways, shall be secured to prevent accidental displacement or a barricade shall be used to keep the activities or traffic away from the ladder.

5.1.8 Ladders shall not be spliced together to form longer sections.

5.1.9 Prior to climbing and extension ladder, the user shall ensure that the locking clips (stops) are securely in place.

5.1.10 Ladders used to gain access from one level to another shall be long enough for the top to extend 3 feet above the landing or suitable grab rails shall be provided for safe movement to or from the point of access.

5.1.11 The platform and top step of ordinary types of stepladders shall not be used as steps.

5.1.12 Cross-bracing on the rear section of stepladders shall not be used for climbing unless the ladder is designed and provided with steps for climbing on both front and rear sections.

5.1.13 Stepladders shall not be used as straight ladders, and shall be used with legs fully extended.

5.1.14 Ladders shall not be used as braces, skids, levers, runways, platforms, scaffolds, or for any other purpose for which they are not intended.

5.1.15 Ladders shall not be climbed by more than one person at a time unless designed to support more than one person.

5.2 CARE OF LADDERS

5.2.1 Ladders shall be handled with care and shall not be subjected to unnecessary abuse or misuse.

5.2.2 Immediate inspection and appropriate maintenance shall be required of any ladder exposed to fire, subjected to damaging chemicals, involved in a fall or collision, or which has become coated with oil or grease.

5.2.3 When not in use, ladders shall be stored where they are protected from potential damage by collision, temperature, moisture, etc.

5.2.4 Ladders shall be returned to the proper storage location when the job is completed.

5.2.5 Ladders shall not be painted.

5.3 TRAINING REQUIREMENTS

5.3.1 The Key Supervisor shall train each employee using ladders. This program shall enable each employee to recognize hazards related to ladders.

5.3.2 The Key Supervisor shall ensure that each employee has been trained by a competent person in the following areas, as applicable:

- The nature of fall hazards in the work area.
- The correct procedures for erecting, maintaining, and disassembling the fall protection system to be used.
- The proper construction, use, placement, and care in handling of ladders.
- The maximum intended load-carrying capacities of ladders used.
- The requirements contained in this procedure.

5.3.3 Retraining shall be provided for each employee as necessary so that the employee maintains the understanding and knowledge acquired through compliance with this procedure.

6.0 RECORDS

Not Applicable

7.0 REFERENCES

ANSI A14.1 Ladders – Portable Wood – Safety Requirements ANSI A14.4 Safety Requirements for Job-Made Ladders ANSI A14.5 Safety Requirements for Portable Reinforced Plastic Ladders

8.0 ATTACHMENTS

Not Applicable

MISH 17 — Use and Care of Ladders

Scan to view this section online, download the PDF, or access the full MH Construction Safety Manual.

https://www.mhc-gc.com/resources/safety-manual/section/use-and-care-of-ladders